SPORTS

SHOOTING FOR THE STARS

Having won three medals at the recent ISSF World Cup, ***Esha Singh****, 17, is now the shooter to beat*

Esha Singh was 10 when she first visited shooter Gagan Narang's Gun for Glory Shooting Academy in Pune. Walking around the facility, she noticed posters of Narang flashing his 2012 Olympic bronze medal. "I remember thinking, 'Wow, it would be so nice to win an Olympic medal and have my photos everywhere.' Over time, I got very interested in the journey to the Olympics—like working really hard and achieving things along the way," Singh, now 17, says.

Earlier this month, Singh proved she didn't just have the ambition required for Olympic glory but also the skill. The ISSF World Cup in Cairo was the pistol shooter's first senior international championship. India topped the standings with seven medals—Singh picked up three—two golds (10m and 25m team events) and a silver (10m individual event). "It was really hectic since I was part of six events. There wasn't a single break day, so I would rest whenever possible and eat and hydrate well. And, of course, enjoy my World Cup debut," she says.

As a child, Singh was exposed to a number of sports by her father, Sachin, a former rally driver. Just months after picking up a pistol, Singh, then only 10, took gold at a state level meet. "Dad always knew that pursuing a sport means you will be disciplined all your life. Mom, on the other hand, couldn't get over the fact that I had picked up yet another sport. She was the one who would take me to multiple classes," Singh says, laughing. "Back then, nobody expected me to take shooting so seriously." Once Singh's commitment was beyond doubt, her father built her a shooting range at home. She continues to train there even today. "Shooting has taught me to be more patient and I have come to realise how important it is to control your mind. It is just something I have learnt from experience," she adds.



ESHA SINGH holds up one of her gold medals from her wins at the ISSF World Cup in Cairo

Of the many things Singh has to look forward to in her future, the first is a driving licence. She remembers going on long drives as a three-year-old, sitting pretty in her dad's lap, pretending to drive on her own. "Dad allows me to drive in parking lots these days. I just love how it feels. He had told me he will get me into rallying once I turn 18, but honestly, I do not know if I will have the time," says Singh. ■

–Shail Desai



MIND OVER MATTER

Pravin Tambe *made headlines when he made his IPL debut at the age of 41. The Maharashtrian player was soon approached by Sudip Tewari of Bootroom Sports Media to make a film on his inspiring journey. "I was surprised because I felt I hadn't accomplished much," says Tambe. On April 1, Disney+ Hotstar releases* Kaun Pravin Tambe? *in which Shreyas Talpade plays the cricketer who is now a part of Kolkata Knight Riders' coaching staff.*

Excerpts from an interview:

Q By 41, most players have given up the dream of playing professional cricket but not you...

My passion for cricket kept me going. Whenever I had time, I would play cricket and I wanted to play well. I never factored in my age while doing so. I knew I could field or catch regardless of it, so I didn't let it bother me when people doubted me. Nothing comes easy in life. I put in the work. I made it a point to balance my work and cricket.